People Who are Deaf or Hard of Hearing

- There is a difference between hard of hearing and deaf. People who are hearing impaired vary in the extent of hearing loss they experience. Some are completely deaf, while others can hear some sounds with hearing aids.
- Hearing aids do not guarantee that the person can hear and understand speech. They increase volume, not necessarily clarity.
- If possible, flick the lights when entering an area or room to get their attention.
- Establish eye contact with the individual, not with the interpreter, if one is present.
- Use facial expressions and hand gestures as visual cues.
- Check to see if you have been understood; repeat and rephrase if necessary.
- Offer pencil and paper. Write slowly and let the individual read as you write.
- Written communication may be especially important if you are unable to understand the person's speech.

- Speak slowly and clearly, but do not over-enunciate.
- Do not block your mouth with your hands or an object when speaking.
- Do not allow others to interrupt you while conveying emergency information.
- Be patient – the person may have difficulty understanding the urgency of your message.
- Provide the person with a flashlight to signal their location in the event they are separated from the rescue team. This will facilitate lip-reading or signing in the dark.
- Written communication will work for many people who are deaf. Keep instructions simple, in the present tense and use basic vocabulary. American Sign Language (ASL) is its own language and not a manual form of English. It has its own syntax and grammar. Native ASL users may read and write English as a second language.